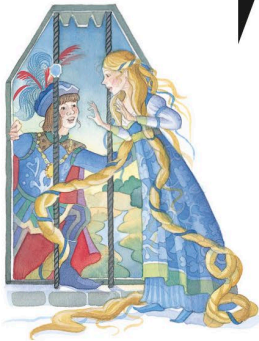




A First Book of

FAIRY TALES



and

A First Book of

MYTHS



Stories retold by Mary Hoffman

A First Book of

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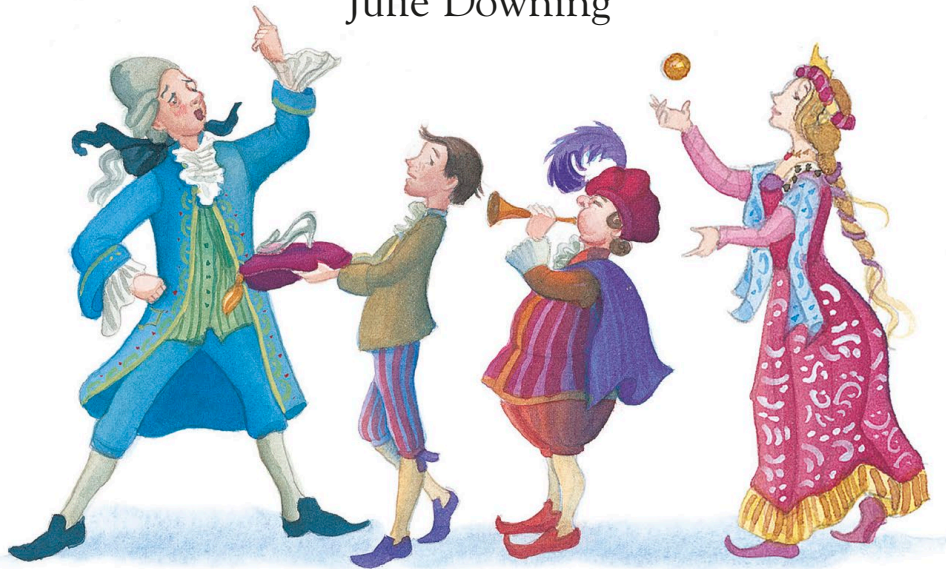


Stories retold by Mary Hoffman
Illustrated by Julie Downing

A First Book of
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TALES**

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The Little Mermaid

In the depths of the ocean, where the water is bluest, is the kingdom of the mer-people. It was here that the mer-king lived with his old mother and his daughters, the six mer-princesses, in the most beautiful palace you could imagine.



One by one, when they reached their fifteenth birthday, the princesses were allowed to visit the world above the water. The youngest princess couldn't wait for her turn to come. At last, when it was her fifteenth birthday, her grandmother said it was time for her to visit the human world.





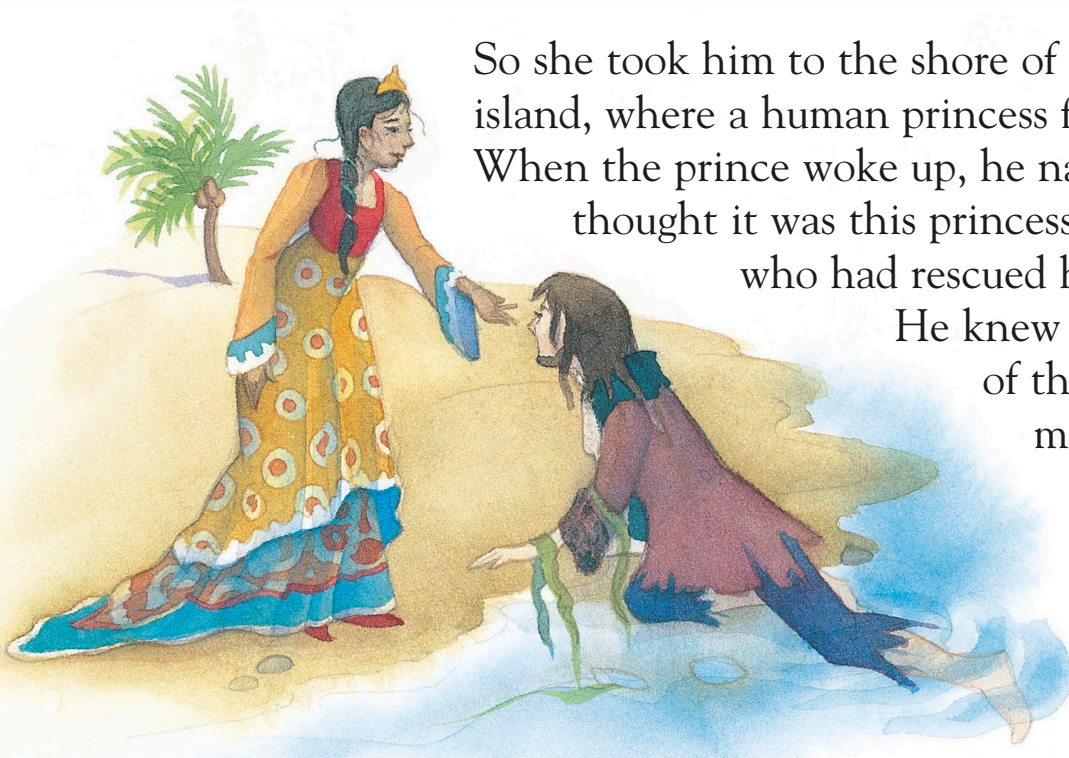
The little mermaid rose above the foam and caught her breath in surprise. The world was so very much more wonderful than she had imagined.



All those on board were tossed into the water. The prince would surely have drowned if the little mermaid hadn't caught him in her arms. But she knew she couldn't take him back to her kingdom.



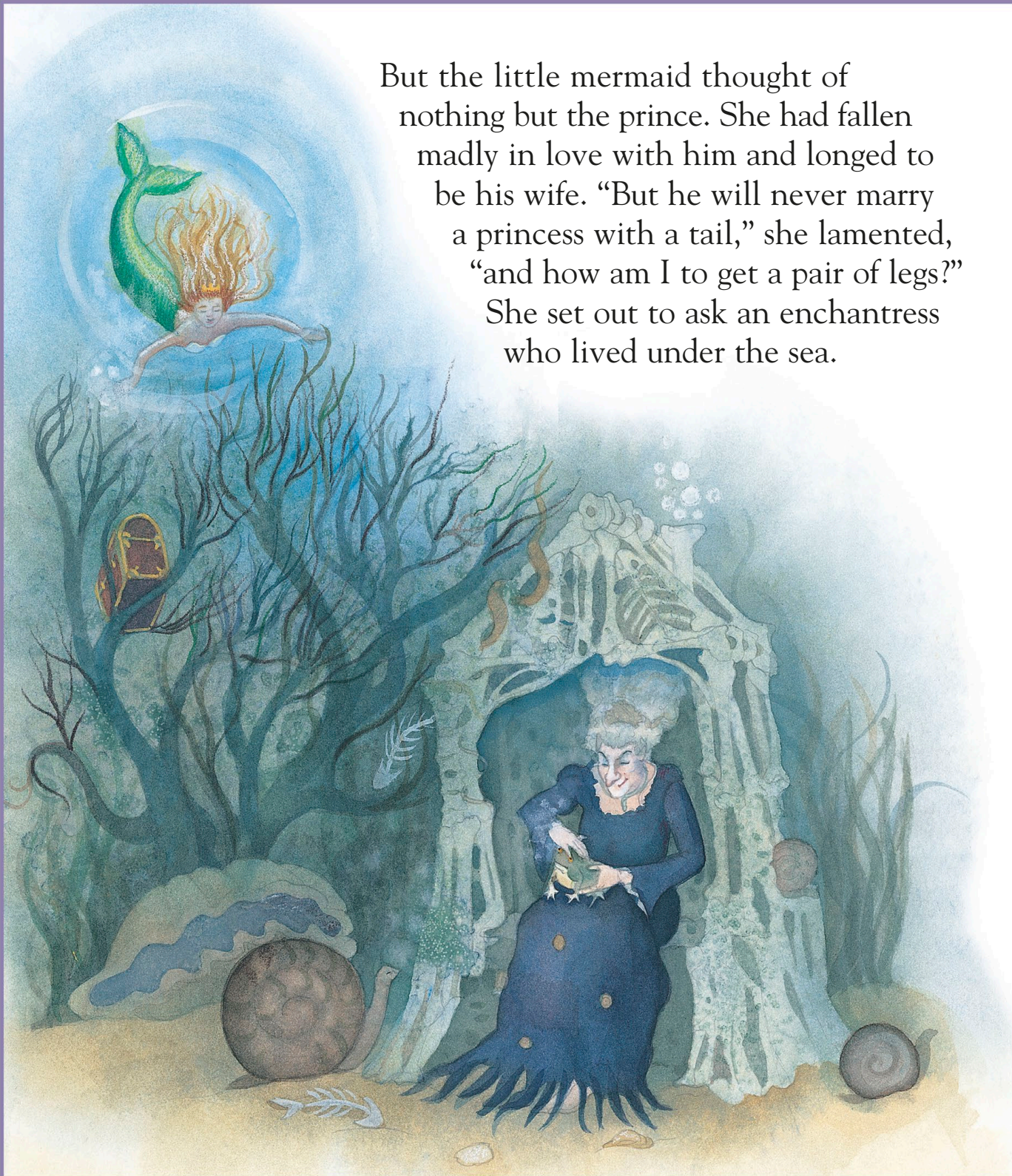
The first thing she saw was a huge ship. And on board there was a birthday party for a handsome prince. But while the little mermaid watched, a terrible storm blew up.



So she took him to the shore of an island, where a human princess found him. When the prince woke up, he naturally thought it was this princess who had rescued him.

He knew nothing of the little mermaid.

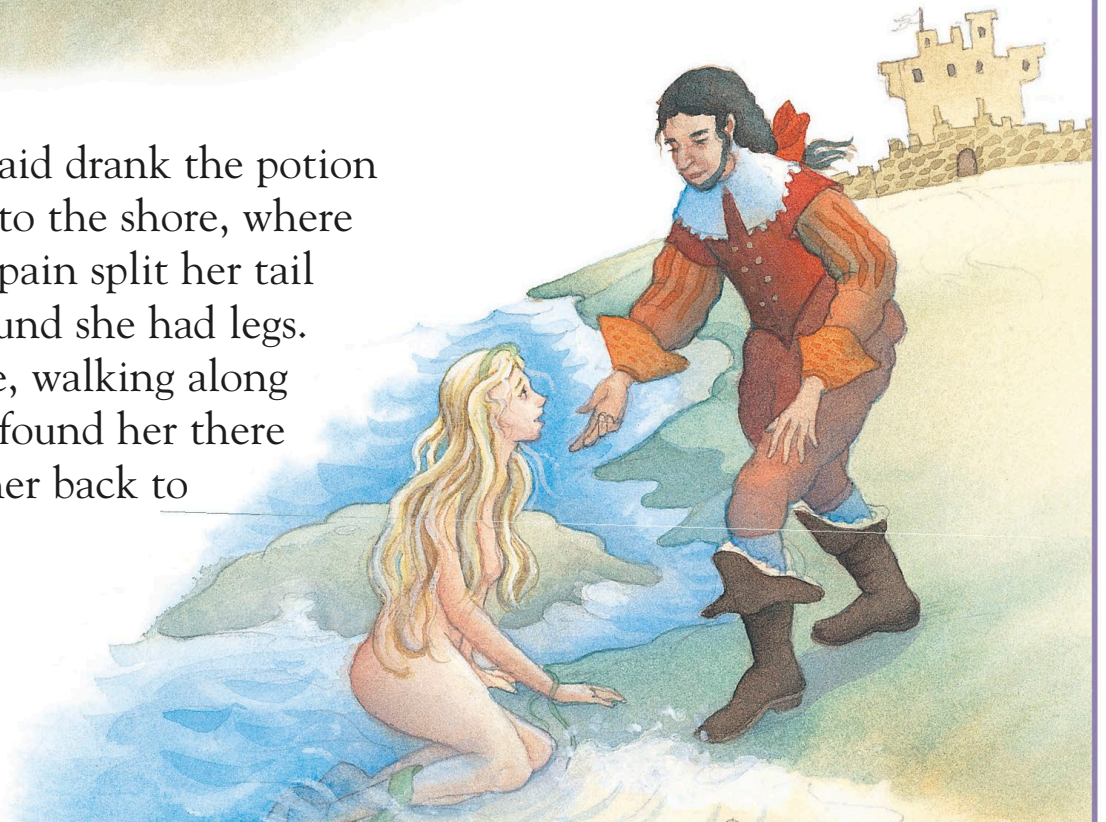
But the little mermaid thought of nothing but the prince. She had fallen madly in love with him and longed to be his wife. "But he will never marry a princess with a tail," she lamented, "and how am I to get a pair of legs?" She set out to ask an enchantress who lived under the sea.





The enchantress gave her a potion, but the mermaid had to pay a terrible price. She would lose her beautiful voice and feel pain every time she walked. But worst of all, the mermaid would turn into foam if the prince did not love her.

The mermaid drank the potion and swam to the shore, where a dreadful pain split her tail and she found she had legs. The prince, walking along the shore, found her there and took her back to his palace.





The little mermaid became the prince's constant companion. She rode with him by day and danced for him every evening, even though the pain in her legs was like dancing on swords. But he did not love her.

The prince had never forgotten the other princess, the one he believed had rescued him from drowning. And now he decided to marry her.

The little mermaid watched the whole ceremony with a broken heart. She knew that she would turn into foam as soon as he kissed his bride.



Her sisters
swam to her and
gave her a knife
to kill the prince.
“It’s the only way to
save your own life,”
they said.



The little mermaid could
not do it. She loved the
prince too much. She kissed
him goodbye and gave herself
up to become foam.



But the spirits of the air
took pity on her and whisked
her up to live with them.
They promised that if she did
good deeds for three hundred
years, she would live forever.

